

optionally choose each type of effect that should be enabled from here, but if it's power you are looking for, leave them all off. Note that the behaviour and appearance of a lot of Windows such as the Control Panel, will become quite different. If you prefer the helpful wizard-like interfaces, you may want to sacrifice a bit on performance and enable the option to 'Use common tasks in folders'.

Paging options

On the Performance Options dialog (right-click My Computer and click **Properties > Advanced > Settings**), click on the Advanced tab to access even more performance features. You can adjust the processor and memory options, but for desktop PCs



Changing swap file settings in XP

you should leave the default options (optimise for Programs). What you should change are the virtual memory settings. You can have one swap file per drive (Check the tip 'Optimise virtual memory' in the Windows 98 section for more on swap files). Set the

optimum size and click OK.

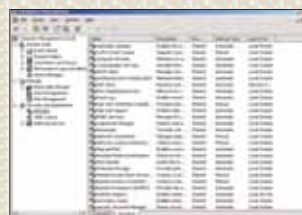
Boot options

If you are not booting multiple operating systems, you can turn off the option permanently, until it is required. If there is another OS on your system, say Windows 98, you can reduce the amount of time the option to choose which OS to load is displayed. Right-click My Computer, click **Properties > Advanced** and click the Settings button under Startup and Recovery. Here, you can choose which operating system to boot by default. You can uncheck the boxes to show the boot options, or select the number of seconds for which the choices are displayed. Five seconds is usually more than enough.

You will notice recovery settings in case of a system failure. Alerts and debugging information will not be very helpful for most users, so you can turn these options off too.

Turn off services

Depending on your computer's configuration and options chosen when installing Windows XP, it will have certain services enabled. Many of these you may never require and can safely switch off. You can disable a service so that it



Reduce load on CPU and RAM by turning off services

never runs, or set it to be manually started.

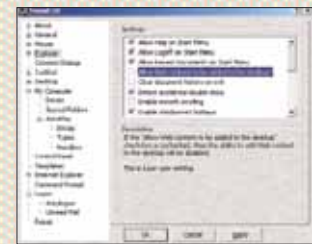
Right-click My Computer and click Manage to bring up the Computer Management console. On the left pane, select Services under Services and Applications to control all installed services. The easiest way to filter through the list is to sort it by the Status column. Services that are 'Started' are the ones you need to look at. (Read more on services in the tip 'Get rid of services' under Windows 2000 Professional'.)

Quit indexing

The Indexing Service stores information from documents and organises it for faster searches. This is not useful to many users, especially if the documents are well organised. Not only does this service take up system resources, it also involves frequent read/write operations to the hard disk, which are particularly slow. From the Computer Management console (right-click My Computer and click Manage), select Indexing Service from the left pane under Services and Applications. You will see the list of catalogues on the right pane. If any of them are started, you can stop them from here, and even delete the catalogue. Optionally, you can expand the tree on the left pane for each indexed item and restrict the folders it scans.

Tweak UI for XP

Tweak UI is available for Windows XP too. It gives you access to quite a few system settings that are otherwise not readily available, and can help



Power up with Tweak UI for XP

gain that extra inch of power from XP. You can download this version from www.microsoft.com/windowsxp/pro/downloads/power toys.asp.

Under General, you can turn off display effects such as fading and animations. Under Explorer, uncheck the boxes for 'Allow Web content to be added to the desktop' and 'Enable smooth scrolling'. Expand the Explorer tree, select Thumbnails and move the Image Quality slider to around the centre. Next, expand the **My Computer > AutoPlay** branch. Under Drives, you can disable AutoPlay for all drives, thus reducing this overhead. Under the Types branch, you can choose to disable AutoPlay for CD, DVD and removable drives.

Under the Command Prompt branch, you can configure special keys to automatically complete file and directory names, as on a Unix system. If you have a single-user system, you can have XP logon automatically from **Logon > Autologon**. Under **Logon > Unread Mail**, you can disable the notification of new e-mail messages for each user. Not only is this more secure, but it also reduces the overhead of polling for new messages for every user. ■